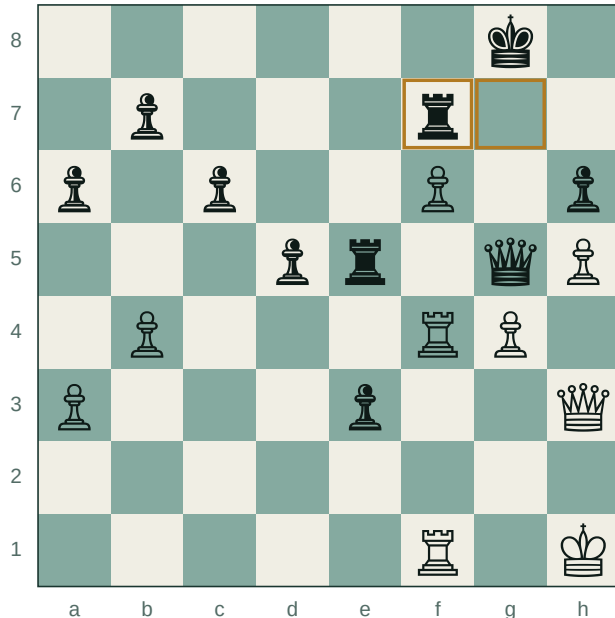


Trapping a piece: White, move 38

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 37...Rf7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

38. Rf5 e2 39. Rxc5+

38.Rf5 The rook moves from f4 to f5. From f5 it attacks queen on g5 and rook on e5. Recorded reply: **38...e2**.

39.Rxc5+ Check restricts Black to 6 legal replies here. From g5 it attacks king on g8 and rook on e5.

At the end, nominal material is White 24 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +9: the balance goes from -1 to +8. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.